

The Architecture of Grace

BOOK ONE · THE FOUNDATION



Autism-Adapted Edition

Visual Anchor Charts

TEACHER SUPPLEMENT

Grades K–2 · Early Childhood

Designed for autistic learners with moderate support needs · one chart per page

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Before You Begin

What changes for moderate support needs

This supplement is the same fourteen anchor charts from *Architecture of Grace · Book One · The Foundation*, redesigned by a multidisciplinary team — autism specialist, school psychologist, school social worker, special education teacher, speech-language pathologist, and occupational therapist — with autistic learners with **moderate support needs** held as the design audience.

What did NOT change

- Every construct — *Grace, Forgiveness, Trust, Kind Coach, Grumpy Gus, Sammy* — is the same construct.
- The theoretical foundation — Brown, Neff, Enright & Fitzgibbons — is preserved.
- Sammy remains the relational anchor. The Disclosure Protocol remains unchanged.

What changed in every chart

- **Drastically reduced text density** — one idea per visual element. Large type. White space.
- **Symbol support throughout** — AAC-compatible vocabulary.
- **Choice boards and First-Then structures** replace most reflection prompts. Pointing is a full response.
- **Every chart includes an Adult Script** — exact words for co-regulation, not just instruction.
- **Two charts replaced.** Three-Panel Story → *My Picture*. Pause Practice → *When Something Surprises Me*. Both preserve the lesson's purpose at a developmentally honest level.

Co-regulation is the model

For students with moderate support needs at this age, regulation happens *with* a trusted adult. **The chart is the script the adult uses with the student** — read aloud slowly, with predictable phrasing.

A NOTE ON TERMINOLOGY

Support needs are not static. A student with moderate support needs most days may need more support during a fire drill, or less during a quiet activity in their special interest. The chart is a tool; the adult is the regulator.

My Picture

Things about me

This is me.



Things I LOVE

people · food · songs · things



Things I'm GOOD AT

small things count



Things That FEEL GOOD

soft things · quiet · music



Things I'm LEARNING

it is okay to be learning

All of these are **me**.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“This is your picture. There is no wrong way to do this. You can draw. You can point. You can use words. You can stay quiet. Show me one thing you LOVE. (wait) Good. That is in your picture.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The original Identity Web has five branches. For moderate support needs at K–2, we reduce to four pictographic categories with concrete examples. Point/tap/draw responses are all valid. Special interests belong in “Things I LOVE” at full intensity — do not redirect a student who fills the LOVE category with one topic. Build over multiple lessons if needed. Post BEFORE the worksheet. Keep posted all year.

My Feelings

Where I feel it · What it is · What I need



HAPPY



SAD



ANGRY



SCARED



TOO MUCH



TIRED



PROUD



NOT SURE

Point to one. That is okay.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Look at the chart. Can you point to how you feel? (wait) Thank you. Where do you feel it? (point to your own body) Here? Here? (wait) What helps when you feel ___? Do you need a hug, a break, a quiet place, or someone with you?”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The chart is a **choice board**, not a vocabulary lesson. Pointing is a full response. “NOT SURE” is a valid choice and must stay on the chart — autistic students with moderate support needs may have significant interoception differences, and “not sure” is honest, not non-compliance. Pair this chart with a body diagram and four cards: *hug · break · quiet · person with me*. The student can point to one, two, or all. Keep posted all year.

Oops → Fix It → Try Again

Three steps when something goes wrong



A mistake is not who you are.
It is something that happened.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

Step 1 — Oops: “Something went wrong. That’s okay. Let’s say it together: oops.”

Step 2 — Fix It: “What can we do? Let’s pick one.” (offer 2 choices on cards: Say Sorry · Try a Different Way)

Step 3 — Try Again: “Now we try again. We can do it together.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

For students with **moderate support needs**, the three steps are most effective when paired with **physical cue cards** — print the three boxes above and place them on the student’s desk as a visual sequence. The student can point to where they are in the sequence. The “Fix It” step always offers 2 concrete choices on cards, never open-ended. *The grown-up co-regulates through the sequence with the student — this is co-regulation, not instruction.* Reference every day all year.

Kind Coach & Grumpy Gus

Two voices Sammy uses · Two ways to talk to ourselves

WHAT THIS MEANS

Sammy is a puppet. The voices are pretend. They show us two ways we can talk to ourselves.

GRUMPY GUS



“You are bad.”
“You always mess up.”

KIND COACH



“Oops — try again.”
“What can I learn?”

We **choose** the Kind Coach.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Listen. Sammy can talk in two ways. (use Grumpy Gus voice) ‘You always mess up!’ That is Grumpy Gus. (use Kind Coach voice) ‘Oops — let’s try again.’ That is the Kind Coach. Which one helps us feel better? (wait for student to point) Good. We choose the Kind Coach.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Critical safety note: for some students with auditory processing differences or sensory sensitivities, the Grumpy Gus voice can be distressing even when it is theatrical. **Calibrate the voice to your specific students.** A whisper version of Grumpy Gus may be needed; the volume of the contrast does not need to be large to make the point. The plain-words box at the top is essential — read it aloud. Color-code red/green. Post permanently.

Oops vs. “I Am Bad”

A thing I DID · Not who I AM

OOPS



What I DID.

“I made a bad choice.”

“I AM BAD”



Who I AM.

Never true about a person.

*You are **not** bad.*

A mistake is something that happened.

FOR EVERYONE IN THIS ROOM

If someone tells you that **you are bad** — they are wrong.

Being different is not being bad.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

*“Sometimes we make mistakes. That is okay. Mistakes can be fixed. **YOU are not a mistake.** You are always you. Mistakes are things that happen — they are not who you are.”*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Many autistic students with moderate support needs have already received heavy doses of identity-level feedback by Grade 1 — often labeled as “behaviors” when the behaviors were sensory responses, dysregulation, or communication needs. The plain-words box and the adult script are doing the heavy lifting here. Read both aloud. Watch for students who go very still — note privately. Follow Disclosure Protocol if anything else surfaces.

Forgiveness

The Heavy Backpack · Putting down what is heavy inside

WHAT FORGIVENESS IS

Sometimes our inside feels heavy — like a backpack full of rocks. Forgiveness means putting some rocks down — for ME.



*Forgiveness is **for ME**.
Not for the person who hurt us.*

SAFETY FIRST

You do NOT have to forgive someone who is still hurting you.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

*“Sometimes we carry hard feelings — like rocks in a backpack. They make us tired. Forgiveness means we put a rock down. We don’t forget. We don’t say it was okay. **We just don’t carry it any more.** Putting a rock down is for US — so we feel lighter.”*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Use the backpack prop with literal rocks (or weighted bean bags) — the physical sensation of weight on/off matters more than the abstract concept for students with moderate support needs. The “still hurting you” safety panel is non-negotiable. Many students at this level cannot verbally disclose harm and rely on adults to keep the door open with explicit chart language.

A Real Sorry

Three things to say



“I ____.”

Say the thing you did. Example: “I knocked over your blocks.”



“That made you feel ____.”

Say how the person felt. Example: “That made you feel sad.”



“Next time I will ____.”

Say what you will do different. Example: “Next time I will walk around.”

All **three** together — that is a real sorry.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Let’s try saying sorry together. I’ll go first. (model all three parts slowly) Now you. Part one: ‘I ____.’ (wait, support). Part two: ‘That made you feel ____.’ (wait). Part three: ‘Next time I will ____.’ (wait). You did it. That is a real sorry.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The three-part structure works best when each part is on a separate physical card the student can hold or point to. Some students will need to use the cards with adult voicing for many months before they can produce the words themselves. *The cards work even if the words don’t yet.* Also: if the student did not mean to hurt the other person, the sorry is still valid — Part 2 (naming the hurt) does not mean admitting bad intent. Walk through each part slowly with the class.

Being Kind to Me

Three things I can say to myself



“I care about me.”

Talk to yourself nicely.



“Other people have hard days too.”

You are not the only one.



“Right now I feel ____.”

Notice the feeling. It will not last forever.

Be kind to **YOU** — like you would to a friend.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“When something is hard, we can say three things to ourselves. Repeat after me: ‘I care about me.’ (pause) ‘Other people have hard days too.’ (pause) ‘Right now I feel ____.’ (let student fill in). Three things. We can say them whenever we need to.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Echolalia is welcome here — many students with moderate support needs will repeat the scripts verbatim, and that is functional self-talk, not failure. The scripts ARE the lesson, not a scaffold for the lesson. Print on cards for students to hold. Reference in every Unit 2 lesson. Adapted from Dr. Kristin Neff’s Self-Compassion framework.

When the Heavy Feeling Comes Back

What I can do



PUT IT DOWN AGAIN

It is okay if it comes back. We put it down again.



TELL A GROWN-UP

Someone on my Support Web.



BE KIND TO ME

Use my three kind sentences.



DID I FIX IT?

If yes — the heavy feeling can stop.

*The heavy feeling can come back.
I can **put it down** again.*

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Sometimes the heavy feeling comes back. That is okay. Look at the chart. You can pick one — put it down again, tell a grown-up, be kind to yourself, or check ‘did I fix it?’ (point to choices). What does your body need right now?”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

This chart is a choice board — the student can point to whichever option fits. All four are valid; the lesson does not require the student to pick a “correct” one. The chart references the Support Web (U2·L6) and the three kind sentences chart (U2·L4) — make sure those are visible in the room. Keep posted through Unit 2.

Forgive ≠ Trust

Two different choices

FORGIVE



Put down the rocks.

For ME.

TRUST



Earned over time.

Watch what they DO.

*You can **forgive** someone
AND still keep your distance.*

PATTERNS ARE INFORMATION

One time + change = okay.

Many times + same problem = a pattern. Trust your read.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Forgiving and trusting are not the same. Forgive means: put down the heavy feeling. Trust means: I believe you will be safe with me. We can forgive — and still be careful. If someone keeps hurting you, you are **allowed** to keep your distance. Tell a grown-up.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The pattern-tracking guardrail is essential here. Autistic children with moderate support needs are often particularly vulnerable to being told to “give another chance” — both because they comply with adult coaching and because their pattern detection of social dynamics is harder under cognitive load. The chart says clearly: noticing a pattern is a skill they are allowed to use. Build with students through co-construction. Keep posted for the rest of Unit 3.

Where I Am Today

No wrong answer

Point to where you are today.



STILL HURTING

My hurt is real.



THINKING ABOUT IT

Trying to understand.



PUTTING IT DOWN

Today, I am putting it down.



I AM OKAY

I remember — and I'm okay.

Wherever you are **is okay**.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Look at the four pictures. Where are you today? You can point. You can stay quiet. (wait). Tomorrow you might point to a different one. That is okay. We can come back to this chart every day.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Reduced from six stations to four for cognitive accessibility. Pointing is the full response. If a student consistently points to “Still Hurting” across multiple lessons, that is information — note privately, follow Disclosure Protocol if anything else surfaces, but staying at “Still Hurting” is not by itself a sign of a problem. The dot placement (or pointing) is always anonymous. Wherever the student is — is okay.

My Story — In a Picture

What I carry · What I am · Private

Some things are private.
You don’t have to share.

WHAT HAPPENED



Private.

Yours to keep.

WHO I AM



I am ME.

More than what happened.

*You are **more** than any hard thing that happened.*

PRIVATE MEANS PRIVATE

Your story is yours.

You do NOT have to tell anyone.

Not the teacher. Not Sammy. Not your friend.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

*“Everyone carries some hard things. They are private. You don’t have to tell anyone. **Even if I ask, you can say no.** You are still you — bigger than any hard thing. If something hard is happening RIGHT NOW, you can tell a grown-up on your Support Web. That is different from sharing a story.”*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The original Three-Panel Story is too cognitively demanding for moderate support needs at K–2. We reduce to two visual panels with the same theoretical purpose: distinguishing experience from identity, and protecting privacy. **The privacy line must be load-bearing** — students at this level often comply with adult prompts and may share things in writing or drawing that they would never speak. The script explicitly tells the student they can say no. The distinction between “private story” and “active harm reporting” is also explicit — privacy does not block disclosure of ongoing harm. Panel 1 is always private. Period.

A Kind Choice

Grace · A choice I make · Not a rule

WHAT GRACE IS

Being kind to someone — even when they did **not** earn it. A choice. Not a rule.

GRACE



I chose to be kind.

I can also say no.

DOORMAT



I felt I had to.

Not the same as kind.

Grace is a **choice**.
You can also say **NO**.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Being kind to someone who didn’t earn it — that is grace. Grace is something we CHOOSE. We are not the rug at the door. We can also say no. (point to chart) Grace = my choice. Doormat = I felt I had to. Both feel different inside.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

For autistic students with moderate support needs, the “you can also say no” line is particularly important. Many have been trained — often well-meaningly — to comply with every social request as a safety strategy. This chart says explicitly: *kindness without choice is not the goal*. Use the doormat physically (a real welcome mat) to demonstrate the distinction. Post alongside the grace definition BEFORE any scenario work.

When Something Surprises Me

What I do before I react

1

STOP

Take a breath. Wait.

2

ASK A GROWN-UP

“What just happened?” — ask someone you trust.

3

CHOOSE WHAT TO DO

With the grown-up’s help. Together.

IF IT KEEPS HAPPENING

If the same thing keeps happening and it hurts —
tell a grown-up. That is information.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

*“Sometimes things surprise us. We don’t know why someone did something. **Stop. Take a breath. Find a grown-up.** The grown-up will help you figure out what just happened — and what to do next. You don’t have to do it alone.”*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The original Pause Practice asks the student to mentally generate “another way to see this — a kind one.” That perspective-taking task is significantly harder for students with moderate support needs at K-2 AND can train them to override accurate threat detection. We replace it with a co-regulated routine: stop → ask a grown-up → decide together. The pattern guardrail is preserved at the bottom. This is the most important adaptation in this book. Post BEFORE the scenario practice. Keep permanently.

A Note to the Teacher

What this moderate-support supplement asks of you

The students you are teaching from this supplement are doing real cognitive and emotional work to be in your room. Many have receptive language that lags chronological age. Many have interoception differences that make emotion-naming difficult. Many use AAC, partial verbal speech, or have functional speech but with significant processing demands. **Every chart in this book assumes you — the trusted adult — are the co-regulator.**

What we ask you to honor

- **Pointing is a full response.** So is staying quiet. So is repeating the chart back verbatim.
- **Echolalia is functional self-talk.** A student who recites the three kind sentences word-for-word is doing the lesson.
- **Choice boards are not “easier” charts.** They are the developmentally appropriate format — the same cognitive work is happening.
- **Private means private.** The My Story replacement says so explicitly. Honor it.
- **If something keeps happening, the student is telling you.** Pattern recognition is intelligence, not negativity.
- **Co-regulation precedes self-regulation.** You are the regulator until the student can be — and that may take years.

What we ask you to never do

- Never frame compliance as kindness. “Going along with it” is not the same as grace.
- Never collect or display private worksheets. Drawings and writing stay with the student.
- Never assume the absence of verbal report means the absence of understanding. Many students understand far more than they can say.
- Never use the Grumpy Gus voice at full volume with auditory-sensitive students. The contrast can be made quietly.

A FINAL WORD

The original *Architecture of Grace* curriculum is serious work, built on solid research. This supplement exists because every child — including the children whose communication style and processing differ from the curriculum’s default — deserves access to the same theoretical foundation, delivered in a format their nervous system can use. *You are doing extraordinary work. Thank you.*